

Affect-Mood-Meaning

Theoretical reflections on the constitution and analysis of culture in the 21st century

Past

Something left behind to learn from

Present

Imperceptible site of passage to reflect and act towards the future

Future

Open horizon of possibilities to choose from

Stabilised through historicisation

Linear conception of time (Foucault 1966 or Koselleck 1979) enabling structural links between past and future
be they personal, as biography, or communal, as myths or grand narratives

Pasts

Collapsed History

Broad Present

Highly perceptible space

Futures

Daunting horizon

Conflicted through historicisation

present is haunted by 'missed futures' (Fisher 2014), present is in need of a 'future literacy' to cope with the multiple plausible futures available (Urry 2016), present is marked by 'feeling of latency' (Gumbrecht 2014)

The constitution of culture / meaningful human experience is placed under extreme scrutiny

There are evermore definitions of who 'we' are, where 'we' came from, and where 'we' should be heading in the future for what reasons and through what actions.

The idea of 'the human' is questioned in the confrontation with intrusive and ubiquitous technologies that render people as little but an extension of media devices.

Cultural flows take global and dynamic shape (Lash and Urry 1995)

Identities are shaped in continuous self-reflection (Giddens 1991)

Digitality / intelligent machines put into question the human cognitive primacy (Hayles 1999)

Strong yearning for presence and substantiality (Gumbrecht 2003)

Knowledge has become increasingly local (Lyotard 1979)

Cultural imperatives to create new, authentic, and aesthetic/sensual things (Reckwitz 2012)

Human embodiment as bearer against technologies inhuman impact on life (Hansen 2000)

Shift in emphasis
**From culture as shared signs, symbols, and narratives
to culture as shared feelings of being**

On the one side the need to outline new conceptual language on the structural parameters that hold 'us' together and guide our life together in the world.

On the other side the need to establish new tools of cultural analysis that are able to not only to 'read' culture but also 'feel' its material and embodied ground.

Relation between 'artefact-space constellations' and 'emotion discourses'

"[A]ffects only form when a space is practically appropriated by its users, which activates these users' implicit cultural schemes and routines" (Reckwitz 2012).

Embracing pragmatism to avoid sociological reductionism and aesthetic essentialism

Rendering "null and void the sterile oscillation between the meaning contained in the works and the meaning projected arbitrarily onto them."
(Hennion 2008).

Emphasis that presence and embodiment stem from the world (Gumbrecht 2003)

"Not the product of ... unacknowledged cultural goals ... involves a far more passive, undirected, and indeed emergent adaption" (Hansen 2000: 50).

You cannot draw yourself into the world (as already part of it) but only withdraw from it. Affects thus form when withdrawal is 'resisted'.

Possible *solution* in amalgamating 'the social' with 'the world' through pragmatism. However, cost is loss of meso-level structural and political governance.

Possible *alternative* is pulling on the threads, radicalising these distinctions and embracing their processuality instead.

Affect ***(experiential)***

Fleeting feeling of being touched; intensity of a moment and place; the worldly force that sets your mood.

Meaningful in brokering a strong sense of place. Brings into the process of self-reference a sensibility for and possibility of resonance with socio-material exteriority.

Mood ***(structural)***

Culturally and historically specific feelings of being.

Structural property that sits in-between specific spatio-temporal arrangements ('the world') and the gestures and memories directed towards the feelings that emerge on their ground ('the social').

Meaning ***(organisational)***

Gestures, tastes, or expectations deployed to creatively stabilise and move towards feelings of being remembered.

The collective cultural practices that organise and direct attention towards certain sites, moments, and worldly forces that touched people.

Centralising moods, we are able to explain how people today find orientation and stability in life through a dynamic and intimate process of engaging with socio-material surroundings.

Moods provide a structural language for the in-between of 'the world' and 'the social'. This resultingly creates opportunities to scrutinize more fully where, why, and how belongings are constructed today.

This new structural language may thus provide opportunities for a new institutional response to the challenges of cultural citizenship – moving from working on the symbolic resources along which we read and perceive historically towards nurturing greater public responsibility for shared feelings of being and the spaces and practices upon which they unfold.

Thanks!

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